exaggerates the probability of long-shot events, treating chances that may be one in a thousand as though they were one in twenty. So I started to calculate the odds of harm emanating from five hundred lethal pieces, about the size of .50-caliber bullets, falling on 5 billion people over 510 million square kilometers of inhabited earth.

By my calculation, the odds of your staying alive during Skylab's fall were actually not too bad. If five hundred lumps should fall out of the sky at random, the odds of any piece hitting anyone in the world would be about one in two hundred, and of hitting any American, one in three thousand. In fact, NASA had some ability to control Skylab's landing area, so that the odds against an American fatality must have been about twenty thousand to one. Since about 130 Americans were killed in motor vehicle accidents every day that year, the chance of an American's being killed in a car on July 11, 1979, was four hundred thousand times greater than the chance of being killed by Skylab.

Skylab did break up in the atmosphere, but the pieces landed, as NASA had planned, in the Indian Ocean, which is about the least populated part of the world. Few of the pieces even fell on land. Maybe a few Australian sheep were mildly disturbed, but there were certainly no human casualties. The whole thing was a joke.

Three Mile Island, which blew up about the same time that Skylab fell down, was another example of absurd overreaction. The reactor was trashed, but the containment vessel stayed intact and kept the radioactive debris sealed up. The International Atomic Energy Agency report found that no radiation was released outside the plant (unlike at Chernobyl, which had no containment vessel). The press so exaggerated the scope of the damage that millions of Americans are convinced that a major public health disaster occurred.

The truth was quite different. Suppose you had twins, both living on a farm on the edge of Three Mile Island. One fellow was worried